

Swachhata Hi Seva 2026



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Swachhata Hi Seva (SHS) 2026 campaign** is being organised from **17th September to 2nd October 2026** with the theme: **“Swachhata Mein Sahbhag; Swachh Bharat, Viksit Bharat”**.

What are the Key Facts about Swachhata Hi Seva (SHS)?

- **About: Swachhata Hi Seva (SHS)** has been observed annually since **2017** as a cleanliness campaign conducted before **Swachh Bharat Diwas on 2nd October** .
- **Objective:** The campaign aims to promote **voluntary citizen participation and collective ownership of cleanliness** under the broader **Jan Bhagidari approach of the Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM)** .
- **Evolution:** The campaign has expanded towards **sustainable sanitation, waste management, sanitation workers’ welfare, youth participation and collective responsibility** through a **whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach** .



Swachhata Hi Seva 2026

- **Approach:** The campaign follows a **Whole of Government** and **Whole of Society** approach, with emphasis on youth participation, stakeholder responsibility and community ownership.
 - It also focuses on creating awareness about the **Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026** and strengthening the understanding of waste management responsibilities among different stakeholders.



Five Core Activity Pillars of SHS 2026

- **Transformation of Cleanliness Target Units (CTUs) and Clean Public Places:** The campaign focuses on transforming neglected garbage points and difficult-to-clean locations through waste removal, beautification and sustained maintenance.
 - Citizens can report sanitation-related grievances through the **Swachhata App** , and identified locations can be mapped on the SHS 2026 portal.
 - Public and community toilets are assessed through **FACES parameters** , which include **Functional, Accessible, Clean, Eco-friendly and Safe** facilities.
- **Swachh Paathshala - Yuva for Swachhata:** This initiative gives a dedicated role to students and youth in promoting long-term behavioural change towards cleanliness.
 - Students from **Classes 6 to 12** participate in **Swachhata Gyan Yatras** to understand waste management and sanitation practices.
- **SafaiMitra Suraksha Seva Evam Samman Shivirs:** This initiative focuses on sanitation workers and their families by providing health services, safety equipment and welfare support. It aims to recognise the contribution of sanitation workers and improve their working conditions.
- **Jan Bhagidari for Swachhata:** Jan Bhagidari remains a central pillar of SHS 2026 by encouraging citizens and institutions to take responsibility for everyday cleanliness.
 - The campaign promotes awareness about the **Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026** , four-way source segregation, home composting and reduction of littering.
 - It also encourages campaigns against single-use plastics, Swachhata rallies, human chains, public cleanliness pledges and collection drives for reusable household items.
 - The campaign promotes **“Swachh Parv, Harit Parv”** by encouraging eco-friendly and plastic-free celebrations during festivals.

- **Swachhata Se Samridhhi:** This pillar connects cleanliness with **resource recovery and circular economy principles** by promoting the **Reduce, Reuse and Recycle (3R)** approach.
- **Kabaad Se Jugaad** encourages the creation of useful products from discarded materials, while **Kabaad Se Kala** promotes artistic creations using waste materials.
- These initiatives aim to transform waste into resources while encouraging creativity and sustainability.

What are the Key Points About Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM)?

- **About:** Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM) was launched on 2nd October 2014 as one of the world's largest government-led sanitation movements. The SBM logo features Mahatma Gandhi's spectacles, symbolising his emphasis on cleanliness and social responsibility.
 - The logo helped create a strong identity for the cleanliness movement and encouraged public participation.
- **Components of SBM:**
 - **Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G)** : Focuses on rural sanitation, toilet access, usage and solid-liquid waste management.
 - **Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban (SBM-U)** : Focuses on urban sanitation, waste management, public spaces and cleanliness infrastructure.
- **Rural Sanitation Achievements:** Rural India was declared **Open Defecation Free (ODF)** in 2019 .



- **ODF Plus Village:** A village that sustains its **Open Defecation Free (ODF)** status and ensures effective management of **solid waste, liquid waste and visual cleanliness** .
- **Classification of ODF Plus Villages:**
 - **Aspiring:** Manages either **solid waste or liquid waste** .
 - **Rising:** Manages both **solid waste and liquid waste** .
 - **Model:** Manages both waste streams along with **visual cleanliness and ODF Plus awareness messaging** .
- **Urban Sanitation Achievements:**



Conclusion

Swachhata Hi Seva has transformed cleanliness from a government programme into a **people-driven movement**. Its journey from toilet construction to waste management, public-space transformation and behavioural change reflects the evolution of India's sanitation approach. Sustained citizen participation, scientific waste management and dignity for sanitation workers will be essential for achieving a truly **clean, sustainable and inclusive India**.

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

Swachhata Hi Seva has transformed sanitation from a government-led programme into a citizen-driven movement. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is Swachhata Hi Seva (SHS)?

Swachhata Hi Seva is an annual cleanliness campaign launched in **2017** that promotes **citizen participation and collective ownership of cleanliness** under the Swachh Bharat Mission.

Q2. When is Swachhata Hi Seva 2026 being organised?

SHS 2026 is being organised from **17 September to 2 October 2026**.

Q3. What is the theme of Swachhata Hi Seva 2026?

The theme of SHS 2026 is **"Swachhata Mein Sahbhag; Swachh Bharat, Viksit Bharat."**

Q4. What is the objective of SHS?

The objective is to promote **voluntary cleanliness action, behavioural change and community participation** through the **Jan Bhagidari approach**.

Q5. When was the Swachh Bharat Mission launched?

The **Swachh Bharat Mission (SBM)** was launched on **2 October 2014**.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. “To ensure effective implementation of policies addressing the water, sanitation and hygiene needs the identification of the beneficiary segments is to be synchronized with anticipated outcomes.” Examine the statement in the context of the WASH scheme. **(2017)**

Q. How could social influence and persuasion contribute to the success of Swachh Bharat Abhiyan? **(2016)**

Uniform Civil Code



For Prelims: Uniform Civil Code , Article 44 of the Constitution , Fifth and Sixth Schedules , CEDAW, 1979 , Talaq-e-Biddat

For Mains: Uniform Civil Code, UCC vs Religious Freedom, Personal laws and the rights of minorities, Challenges in balancing individual rights with community rights

Source: TH

Why in News?

The debate surrounding the **Uniform Civil Code (UCC)** has regained momentum as **UCC Bills passed by Assam, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh are currently awaiting Presidential assent** , while **Uttarakhand has had a UCC in force since January 2025** . The developments reflect growing efforts to establish a **common civil law framework** covering marriage, divorce, inheritance and adoption.

Summary

- Uniform Civil Code (UCC) aims to establish common civil laws for all citizens in matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption and succession, promoting gender justice, equality and national integration.
- The UCC debate centres on balancing constitutional equality and individual rights with religious freedom, cultural diversity and tribal customary laws, making consensus-based reform crucial.

What is a Uniform Civil Code?

- **Definition:** A Uniform Civil Code envisions a **singular, common set of civil laws governing all citizens of India** equally in matters of **marriage, divorce, custody, adoption, maintenance, inheritance, and succession of property**, irrespective of their religious faith or community affiliations.
- **Dichotomy in Indian Law:** India possesses uniform codes across the **criminal and commercial spectra** (e.g., **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023**, **Indian Contract Act, 1872**, **Transfer of Property Act of 1882**).
 - However, civil personal matters continue to be governed primarily by community-specific personal laws derived from religious texts, traditions, or customary practices.
- **Constitutional Provisions Governing UCC:** **Article 44 of the Constitution**, placed under **Part IV (Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP))**, states: "*The State shall endeavour to secure for the citizens a Uniform Civil Code throughout the territory of India.*"
 - Under **Article 37**, DPSPs are fundamental in the governance of the country, but they are **non-justiciable** (unenforceable by courts).

Current Status of Personal Laws in India

- **Hindus, Buddhists, Jains, and Sikhs:** Broadly codified under the **Hindu Code Bills of 1955-56** (Hindu Marriage Act, Hindu Succession Act, Hindu Minority and Guardianship Act, and Hindu Adoptions and Maintenance Act).
 - Sikh marriages can additionally be registered under the **Anand Marriage Act, 1909 (amended 2012)**.
- **Muslims:** Governed by uncoded or partially codified personal laws based on Shariat, primarily anchored in the **Muslim Personal Law (Shariat) Application Act, 1937**, and the **Dissolution of Muslim Marriages Act, 1939**.
- **Christians and Parsis:** Governed by enactments such as the Indian Christian Marriage Act (1872), the Indian Divorce Act (1869), and the Parsi Marriage and Divorce Act (1936).
- **Tribal Customary Laws:** Protected through constitutional exceptions and safeguards, including provisions under the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules** and **Articles 371**, which protect customary family traditions from standard legislative overriding.
- **Secular Legislation:** Parallel secular options exist for citizens choosing to step outside personal laws, such as the **Special Marriage Act, 1954**.

What are the Arguments For and Against UCC?

Arguments in Favour of UCC	Arguments Against UCC
Gender Justice & Equality: Can ensure uniform rights in inheritance, divorce, marriage and guardianship , strengthening Articles 14, 15 and 21 .	Erosion of Pluralism: Uniform laws may undermine India’s religious and cultural diversity , raising concerns under Articles 25 and 29 .
Constitutional Secularism: Civil rights would be based on citizenship rather than religion , reinforcing secular principles.	Minority Alienation: Without broad consensus, UCC may create fears of majoritarian imposition on minority traditions.
National Integration: Implementing a “One Nation, One Law” approach can establish common civil standards , reduce religion-based legal differences and promote a shared civic identity.	Tribal & Customary Practices: A uniform code may conflict with tribal customs , particularly in the North-East and Fifth Schedule areas . For instance, some OBC communities such as the Kurmis have also expressed concerns about their inclusion under the UCC, highlighting the importance of protecting community-specific customs and identities.
International Obligations: India is a party to the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), 1966 and CEDAW, 1979 . UCC supports India’s commitment to equality and non-discrimination , including gender equality.	Uniformity ≠ Equality: Uniform laws do not automatically ensure substantive equality. Discriminatory provisions could instead be reformed within existing personal laws .

Landmark Supreme Court Pronouncements on UCC

- **Mohd. Ahmed Khan v. Shah Bano Begum (1985):** The Supreme Court upheld the right of a divorced Muslim woman to maintenance under Section 125 of the CrPC and lamented that Article 44 had remained a "dead letter" **and stressed the need for a Uniform Civil Code.**
- **Sarla Mudgal v. Union of India (1995):** The Court held that a Hindu husband cannot convert to **Islam solely to contract a second marriage without dissolving an existing Hindu marriage** and highlighted the need for a UCC to prevent misuse of personal laws.
- **Daniel Latifi v. Union of India (2001):** The Court upheld the Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Divorce) Act, 1986, while ensuring that a divorced Muslim woman receives reasonable and fair provision beyond the Iddat period.
- **John Vallamattom v. Union of India (2003):** The Court struck down Section 118 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925, as discriminatory under **Article 14 and linked a common civil code with national integration.**
- **Shayara Bano v. Union of India (2017):** The Court declared **Talaq-e-Biddat (instant triple talaq) unconstitutional**, reinforcing that personal-law practices can be tested against constitutional principles.
- **Jose Paulo Coutinho v. Maria Luiza Valentina Pereira Case, 2019:** The Court praised Goa as a "shining example" where " **the uniform civil code is applicable to all, regardless of religion, except while protecting certain limited rights**" and **called for its implementation across India.**

Way Forward

- **Prioritising Gender Justice:** The fundamental objective of reforming civil laws must be to secure equal rights for women across all religions in matters of marriage, divorce, maintenance, and inheritance.
- **Upholding Constitutional Morality:** As observed by the Supreme Court in the **Section 6A of the Citizenship Act, 1955 (2024) case**, fundamental rights (like Articles 25 and 29) are subject to **constitutional morality and equality**. Practices running against the spirit of the Constitution (like gender discrimination) do not receive protection under Article 29.
 - Therefore, reforming personal laws to eliminate discrimination should be viewed as upholding the Constitution's spirit.
- **A Voluntary Approach (Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's Vision):** To address resistance and build trust among minority communities, lawmakers could consider Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's suggestion in the Constituent Assembly.
 - He proposed that the application of a UCC could initially be made **voluntary**, applying only to citizens who explicitly declare their willingness to be bound by it.
- **Focus on 'Equality Within Communities':** The **21st Law Commission of India**, in its 2018 *Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law*, concluded that a blanket UCC is "**neither necessary nor desirable at this stage**".
 - Instead of forcing 'equality between communities' (uniformity), the immediate legislative focus should be on achieving '**equality within communities**'.

- This can be achieved by systematically amending discriminatory provisions in various existing personal laws (regarding custody, adoption, succession, etc.) to ensure comprehensive gender justice.

Conclusion

UCC should balance **gender justice, individual dignity and constitutional equality** with India's **religious and cultural diversity** . Its success depends on **broad consultation (including women's groups, communities and stakeholders), consensus-building and sensitivity to customary practices** . The goal should be **inclusive legal reform, not cultural uniformity** .

Drishti Mains Question:

"Article 44 seeks uniformity in civil laws, while Articles 25 and 29 protect India's pluralistic character." Discuss how these constitutional objectives can be reconciled in the context of Uniform Civil Code.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Article 44 of the Constitution?

Article 44 directs the State to **endeavour to secure a Uniform Civil Code** for citizens throughout India. It is part of the **Directive Principles of State Policy** and is non-justiciable under Article 37.

2. Which state first implemented the Uniform Civil Code in independent India?

Uttarakhand brought its UCC into force in **January 2025** , making it the first state in independent India to implement such a comprehensive state-level code.

3. Which Supreme Court cases are important for the UCC debate?

Key cases include **Shah Bano (1985)**, **Sarla Mudgal (1995)**, **Daniel Latifi (2001)**, **John Vallamattom (2003)**, **Shayara Bano (2017)** and **Jose Paulo Coutinho (2019)** . The Court has addressed maintenance, marriage, succession, gender justice and personal-law reform.

4. How does UCC relate to gender justice?

UCC can seek **equal rights in marriage, divorce, maintenance, inheritance, adoption and guardianship** , while removing discriminatory provisions from personal laws.

5. What is the major challenge in implementing UCC?

The key challenge is balancing **equality and individual rights** with **religious freedom, cultural pluralism and tribal customary practices** , while ensuring broad consultation and constitutional safeguards.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/-xuwA3e_XnQ](https://www.youtube.com/embed/-xuwA3e_XnQ)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims :

Q. Consider the following provisions under the Directive Principles of State Policy as enshrined in the Constitution of India: (2012)

1. Securing for citizens of India a uniform civil code
2. Organising village Panchayats
3. Promoting cottage industries in rural areas
4. Securing for all the workers reasonable leisure and cultural opportunities

Which of the above are the Gandhian Principles that are reflected in the Directive Principles of State Policy?

- (a) 1, 2 and 4 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Ans: (b)

Mains:

Q. Discuss the possible factors that inhibit India from enacting for its citizen a uniform civil code as provided for in the Directive Principles of State Policy. (2015)

Role of ECI in Resolving Political Party Disputes & Symbol Allocation



Source: IE

The **Election Commission of India (ECI)** froze the '**All India Trinamool Congress**' name and its reserved symbol due to competing claims from rival factions ahead of the West Bengal Assembly bypolls.

- **Freezing of Symbols:** If the ECI cannot conclude proceedings before an imminent election, it may issue an interim order to **freeze the reserved symbol**.
 - Both factions are then directed to contest under temporary names and choose separate symbols from the ECI's list of 'free symbols'.
- **Legal Framework and ECI's Authority** The ECI derives its authority to resolve party name and symbol disputes from **Article 324 of the Constitution**, the **Representation of the People Act (1951)**, and the **Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968**.
 - **Paragraph 15:** Under the 1968 Order, the ECI is the sole authority empowered to decide which rival faction of a recognised national or state party is the "real" party. Its decision is binding.
 - **Unrecognised Parties:** For registered but unrecognised parties, the ECI does not adjudicate symbol disputes, instead advising internal resolution or directing them to civil courts.
- **The 'Test of Majority':** The Supreme Court in **Sadiq Ali v. Election Commission of India (1971)** upheld the ECI's power under Paragraph 15 to resolve disputes between rival factions of political parties, establishing a **three-test formula for determining the legitimate party group**.
 - **Test of Aims and Objects:** Examining the party's constitution and primary objectives.
 - **Test of Party Constitution:** Evaluating which faction adhered to internal rules and democratically held organisational elections.
 - **Test of Majority (Legislative and Organisational):** The most crucial metric. The ECI assesses the numerical strength of each faction's organisational wing (office bearers, delegates) and legislative wing (elected MPs and MLAs).
- **Fallback Mechanism:** If organisational support is disputed or unclear, the ECI relies heavily on the majority support among the elected legislative representatives.
- **Fate of the Losing Faction** Once the ECI makes a final determination, the faction that loses the claim to the original name and symbol. **It may continue under another name/symbol if allotted by ECI.**
 - It must earn its own State or National recognition based strictly on its future electoral performance, regardless of its past association.

Read more: [Election Symbols](#)

SLINEX-26



Source: PIB

The **13th edition of Sri Lanka-India Naval Exercise (SLINEX -26)** is being conducted at **Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh from 17th -21st September 2026** under the aegis of the Eastern Naval Command.

- **About:** SLINEX is a **bilateral maritime exercise** between the Indian Navy and the Sri Lanka Navy. Conceptualised in **2005** , it has evolved as an important platform for enhancing **maritime cooperation, interoperability and mutual understanding** between India and Sri Lanka.
- **Phases:** The exercise comprises **two phases — Harbour Phase** involving professional interactions and cultural activities, followed by **Sea Phase** focusing on maritime coordination and interoperability.
- **Participating Platforms:** The **Indian Navy** is participating with **INS Kavaratti** , an indigenous **Anti-Submarine Warfare Corvette** , and **INS Jyoti** , the **Fleet Tanker** , while the **Sri Lanka Navy** is represented by **SLNS Sindurala** .
- **Significance:** The exercise is aligned with India’s **MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) vision** , which focuses on promoting a secure, stable and inclusive maritime environment in the Indian Ocean Region.

Read More: [SLINEX-25](#)